STABILITY / UPTIME

ELEVATED

DEPLOYMENT ROLLBACK CRISIS

The latest release broke checkout for 20% of users. Rolling back sounds simple — except the team has never actually practised it, a database migration already ran, and nobody is confident about the current state of production data.

The ability to roll back quickly and safely is a core DevOps capability — the DORA metric 'Mean Time to Restore' (MTTR) is one of the four key engineering performance indicators, and rollback speed is its primary driver. Best practices include: blue-green deployments (keeping the previous version running and switching traffic back instantly), feature flags (toggling off a broken feature without a full deployment), backwards-compatible database migrations (never making a schema change that breaks the previous version of the code), and regular rollback rehearsals. Teams that deploy frequently also roll back frequently — the muscle memory is there when it matters. Canary deployments limit the blast radius of a bad release to a small percentage of users before full rollout.

Rollback plans that exist only on paper fail in production. Practise reversions before you need them.

TEAM DISCUSSION

When did you last rehearse a rollback end-to-end? Can you safely revert in under 15 minutes with confidence?